Many theorists have been predicting a war between China and India. First it was supposed to have happened after the Beijing Olympics, and then it was forecast to take place in 2012, and now there is some talk of 2020. Some of these analysts haven't been to the high Himalayan regions on either side, or have merely undertaken whistlestop tours in fair weather. To comprehend the true dimensions of fighting a war in this region, one has to see the conditions during the freezing winter season, when the snow and the blizzards make life impossible, or during the monsoons, when it rains for days on end and even small streams become raging torrents, washing away bridges and major parts of roads. We need to understand that no modern war can be fought unless it is thought through in its entirety, and more importantly, only if the initiator is convinced that it can be won. Further, to start a nuclear war would be the height of folly. However, I do not wish to give an impression that we can afford to be complacent or let our guard down. In fact, we should continue to modernize our armed forces and improve the infrastructure, strengthen the intelligence agencies and provide them state-of-the-art wherewithal for giving real-time intelligence, and thereby enhance our capability to face the challenges of the future.

Sometime in October 2007, soon after I had handed over the baton of the army chief, I got a call from Professor Stephen P. Cohen, senior fellow, The Brookings Institution, Washington, requesting a meeting at my home in Delhi. I had heard about him and read his book on the army of Pakistan, apart from some other writings. Our free and frank discussion lasted much more than the scheduled 40 minutes. With due respect to the distinguished scholar, at times I found Cohen's perceptions of events a bit unconvincing, and I did not hesitate to speak out my mind. Discussing the situation in Pakistan and its neighbourhood, I highlighted the disastrous consequences of inherent schisms and deep-rooted contradictions within Pakistan, the uncontrolled activities of terrorist organizations all over the country and in the Af-Pak border areas, which have turned Pakistan into the fountainhead of Islamic extremism and